



Working with 'key words' to support understanding

What are key words?

Key words are the words in a sentence that must be understood in order to respond appropriately. Speech and Language Therapists will sometimes refer to key words as **Information Carrying Words** (ICWs).

0 Information Carrying Word: e.g. 'Give me the ball'

If only a ball was visible and the adult is holding out their hand/ gesturing and looking at the desired item, then this instruction would hold **no** information carrying words. The child does not need to make a choice and they can use non-verbal information to follow the instruction.

1 Information carrying word: e.g. 'Give me the **book**'

This instruction has 1 information carrying word, if the child has a book and pencil in front of them and you ask for a book. The word 'book' is the information the child must understand from the 1 choice available book vs pencil.

Objects: book and pencil

2 information carrying words: e.g. 'Put the **book** in the **box**'

This instruction has 2 information carrying words if the child has a book, pencil, box and a bag in front of them. The words 'book' and 'box' are information carrying words which the child must understand from the 2 choices available, book vs pencil and box vs bag.

Objects: book, pencil, box and a bag.

3 information carrying words: e.g. 'Put the **red book** in the **box**'

This instruction has 3 information carrying words if the child has a red book, blue book, red pencil, blue pencil, box and a bag in front of them. The words 'red', 'book' and 'box' are information carrying words which the child must understand from the 3 choices available red vs blue, book vs pencil and box vs bag.

Objects: red book, blue book, red pencil, blue pencil, box and a bag.

4 information carrying words: e.g. 'Put the **red book** **under** the **box**'

This instruction has 4 information carrying words if the child has a red book, blue book, red pencil, blue pencil, box and a bag in front of them. The words 'red', 'book' and 'box' and the preposition 'under' are information carrying words which the child must understand. The child makes 4 choices red vs blue, book vs pencil, under vs in and box vs bag.

Objects: red book, blue book, red pencil, blue pencil, box and a bag.



Working on key words to support understanding

Tips for working on key words

- Make sure you have all the objects ready.
- Get the child's attention before giving an instruction.
- Do not look or point at the objects or pictures.
- Plan what you say and say it once, clearly.
- If the child makes a mistake, put the objects back and repeat the instruction.
- Switch off all background music, televisions and computers because your child will find it much easier to concentrate, listen and learn.
- Keep the sessions short and fun as possible. It is important that your child enjoys the activity because they are more likely to join in and learn.

Home activities for working on key words

Picture Lotto:

- Give your child the base board which has a range of the pictures.
- Place the little pictures in a pile face down. Pick up a picture, name it.
- Wait for your child to point to the correct picture on his base board.
- Give your child the matching small picture and name it again.

Toys:

- Using a teddy and doll (or two other toys) take it in turns to tell each other to:
e.g. 'Wash teddy's ear' 'Brush dolly's hair'

Post box game:

- Use a shoe box or other similar box. Cut a slit in one side of the box large enough to post the small pictures through.
- Tell your child which picture to post. If your child does not name the picture, please just name the picture for them, but do not make them say it again after you.

Simon says:

- Take turns telling each other what to do:
e.g. 'run/hop to the big/little chair/table'

Drawing/ colouring pictures:

- Give simple instructions for your child to draw or colour. E.g 'Draw a tree.' 'Draw a cat in the tree'
'Colour the cat orange.'

